



UNITED STATES OF AMERICA

Capital city:

Washington, DC

Area: 3,717,792 sq miles
(9,626,091 sq km)

Population: 294,000,000

Official language:
English

Major religions: Christian 86%, Jewish 2%, Muslim 2%, other 10%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: Dollar

Adult literacy rate: 99%

Life expectancy: 77 years

People per doctor: 370

Televisions: 847 per 1,000 people


This girl has a mother who is part Hawaiian and part Korean.



This child has Japanese parents who moved to the US during the 1970s.

PEOPLE OF THE US

People in the US belong to a wide range of different groups and races. Most are descended from immigrants – people who moved there from other parts of the world, such as Europe and Asia. Many African-Americans are descendants of slaves forced to the US in the 17th, 18th, and early 19th centuries. Today, the population is increasingly Hispanic (Spanish speaking), Asian, and African-American. By 2050, these groups will make up almost half the population.

African-Americans now make up 13 percent of the population.

This child has Japanese parents who moved to the US during the 1970s.

LIVING IN THE CITY

Almost 80 percent of Americans live in cities or the surrounding suburbs. Most people who live in the suburbs own their own homes and travel to work by car. New York is the biggest city, with more than 22 million inhabitants, followed by Los Angeles, and then Chicago. People from different backgrounds mingle in most cities. Often they have their own neighborhoods, with names such as Little Italy or Chinatown. This view shows midtown Manhattan, New York.

As cities became more crowded, and land more expensive, architects began to design taller and taller buildings where people could live and work.

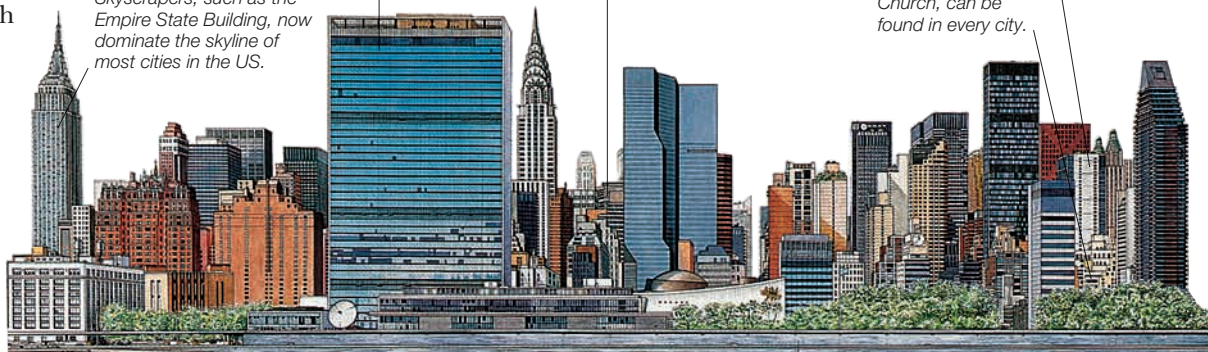
Every day, half a million people use Grand Central Station to get to work.

Many US cities are laid out on a simple grid system where main roads, or avenues, run north to south, and streets run east to west.

Americans live in a variety of homes – single-family homes, townhouses, and high-rise apartment buildings.

Places of worship, like the Holy Family Church, can be found in every city.

Skyscrapers, such as the Empire State Building, now dominate the skyline of most cities in the US.



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IN LESS THAN 400 YEARS, the United States of America (USA) has grown from wild countryside inhabited by native peoples to the world's most powerful industrial nation. The country is made up of 50 states, including Alaska in the far north and Hawaii in the Pacific Ocean. There are two major mountain ranges, the Appalachians to the east and the Rockies to the west, while much of its center is covered by the gently sloping Great Plains. Vast supplies of coal, oil, and minerals, together with mass immigration in the 19th and early 20th centuries, helped business and industry grow fast. Today, American products and culture are recognized throughout the world.



STARS AND STRIPES

On the US flag, the stars stand for the 50 modern states, while the stripes represent the original 13 colonies on the East Coast. Until independence in 1776, these were governed by Britain. Today, each state has its own laws but is ruled by the national government in Washington, District of Columbia.



WORLD LEADER

The US is the world's richest country, and its leading products include iron and steel, lumber and paper products, electronic equipment, cars, and aircraft, shown above. These industries create many jobs, and women now make up almost half of the country's total workforce.